

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Manav Verma

Address: 88 Northey Avenue Cheam SM2 7HJ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to formally object to the above-referenced planning application. I have been a local resident for the last 10 years, currently live in a close vicinity of the site address on Northey Avenue, having previously been a resident of a flat adjoining the boundary of the site address in 2019-20.

While I recognize the importance of providing community infrastructure, this specific proposal conflicts with several key requirements of the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) December 2024 and Sutton Local Plan 2018, and raises significant concerns regarding long-term community integration and equitable resource allocation.

1. Conflict with NPPF Paragraphs 96 and 98 (Social Interaction & Cohesion)

The NPPF (2024) is clear that planning decisions must aim to achieve "healthy, inclusive and safe places." Specifically:

- Paragraph 96(a) requires developments to "promote social interaction... between people who might not otherwise come into contact with each other."

- Paragraph 98 emphasizes the need for shared spaces and community facilities that serve all sections of the community.

By proposing a specialized facility for one specific faith group, this development risks undermining these goals. It creates a "destination" for a specific demographic, which limits the "chance contact"

between diverse residents that is essential for a unified borough of Sutton.

2. Integration Risks and the Casey Review (2016)

The Casey Review warned of the risks of "parallel lives" and residential clustering. The creation of large, concentrated faith facilities often acts as a catalyst for "enclave" formation, leading to:

- Reduced everyday mixing between different ethnic and religious groups.
- Diminished shared British identity and social integration.
- The very "ghettoisation" cautioned against in national social policy.

Experience in nearby areas, such as Morden, demonstrates how significant demographic shifts and "clustering" often followed after the establishment of large-scale, single-use faith centers. In a borough already facing demographic pressures, the Council should prioritize integrated infrastructure that brings people together rather than facilities that entrench separation.

Similar single faith demographic shifts have also been seen in the last 20-30 years across London boroughs namely Tooting, Tower Hamlet, Newham, Barking and Dagenham, Waltham Forest, Brent, Ealing and Hounslow. Trends are also evident across the country: Watford, Birmingham, Bradford, Leeds and many more. I request that the Council conduct a formal study across these boroughs and counties to assess how a single faith centre creates a gradual and structural dilution of diversity of communities.

3. Conflict with Sutton Local Plan (2018) - Policies 21 and 23

The Council's own Local Plan emphasizes the need for social infrastructure that fosters integration rather than separation:

- Policy 21 (Social Infrastructure): This policy requires the Council to ensure that social infrastructure is provided in a way that is "sustainable" and "inclusive." By approving an additional specialized facility for a group that is already well-served (as outlined below), the Council risks failing its duty to ensure a balanced distribution of community assets for all sections of the community.
- Policy 23 (Environmental Protection and Impact): This policy addresses the need for developments to be appropriate to their location. Given the existing concentration of faith-specific facilities in the immediate area (as outlined below), a further single-use mosque would entrench a "mono-cultural" use of land, which directly contradicts the goal of maintaining the diverse, suburban character of Sutton.

4. Disproportionate Allocation relative to Census Data

According to the 2021 ONS Census data for London borough of Sutton, the demographic breakdown is as follows:

Religion. % of Population. Existing Provision

Christians 45.8% (95,983 residents) Multiple operational churches

No religion 32.3% (67,779 residents) -

Muslim. 7.0% (14,722 residents) Multiple operational mosques

Hindu. 7.0% (14,663 residents) Zero

Other Faiths

Combined. 1.0%. Zero

Granting further specialized provision for a group that already possesses multiple functional sites- while other groups of identical or similar size have no dedicated worship space-is a failure of equitable resource allocation. I request that the Council conduct a formal fact-finding exercise to audit existing places of worship against the actual local population needs before making a determination

5. Evidence of Existing Provision (Disproportionality)

Planning decisions must be evidence-led and based on an objective assessment of local need. The 2021 Census confirms that the Muslim and Hindu populations in Sutton are identical in size (7.0%). However, the borough and its immediate borders already feature a significant number of functional masjid and Islamic centres, including:

- Sutton Central Masjid (25 Carshalton Rd, Sutton SM1 4LF)
- Sutton Islamic Centre (62 Oakhill Rd, Sutton SM1 3AG)
- Muslim Cultural & Welfare Association of Sutton (Wentworth Hall, 80 Ruskin Rd, Carshalton SM5 3DH)
- Masjid Abu Bakar Al-Siddiq (The Market, Wrythe Ln, Rosehill SM5 1JQ)
- The Baitul Futuh Mosque and the Morden Islamic Community Centre (Massive regional facilities in Morden).

Granting permission for another facility while other faith groups (and the 32.3% of residents with "No Religion") lack adequate neutral, shared community spaces is a clear breach of the NPPF Paragraph 98 requirement to "plan positively for the provision of shared spaces... for all sections

of the community."

6. Socio-Economic Considerations & Land Use

While the British Muslim community makes a material annual contribution to the UK economy, ONS data indicates that local Muslim residents often face higher rates of economic inactivity (51.4%) and housing deprivation compared to other groups.

Under Sutton Local Plan Policy 21, the council should prioritize infrastructure that addresses these specific socio-economic needs for the entire community. A neutral, multi-use community hub (vocational training, youth services, or recreational space) would provide greater "leveling up" benefits and foster integration, whereas a specialized religious facility risks encouraging residential clustering and the "enclave" formation cautioned against in the Casey Review (2016).

The comparative Economic Data from ONS Census 2021 is provided below for ready reference.

Conclusion

Under NPPF Paragraph 96 (December 2024), the Council has a duty to ensure that planning decisions do not "undermine community cohesion." The clustering of specialized faith facilities, as warned by the Casey Review, leads to parallel lives rather than integrated ones.

I urge the Planning Committee to refuse this application and reflect the diversity of the borough and serves all residents equally, regardless of faith or background.

Yours sincerely
Manav Verma

Comparative Economic Data (ONS Census 2021)

When comparing economic activity and household wealth across community groups, the data shows distinct patterns:

Metric (ONS 2021)

1. Employment Rate:

- Hindus: (16-64) Higher: ~75%-80%
- Christian: Moderate: ~70%
- Muslim: Lower: 51.4%

2. High-Income Households

- Hindus: Highest: ~41% earn £1k+ weekly
- Christian: Average: ~30% earn £1k+ weekly
- Muslims: Lower: ~18% earn £1k+ weekly

3. Housing Tenure

- Hindus: High owner-occupation
- Christian: High owner-occupation
- Muslims: High social renting (26.6%)

4. Economic Activity

- Hindus: Very high
- Christian: Stable
- Muslim: High % of students/home-carers